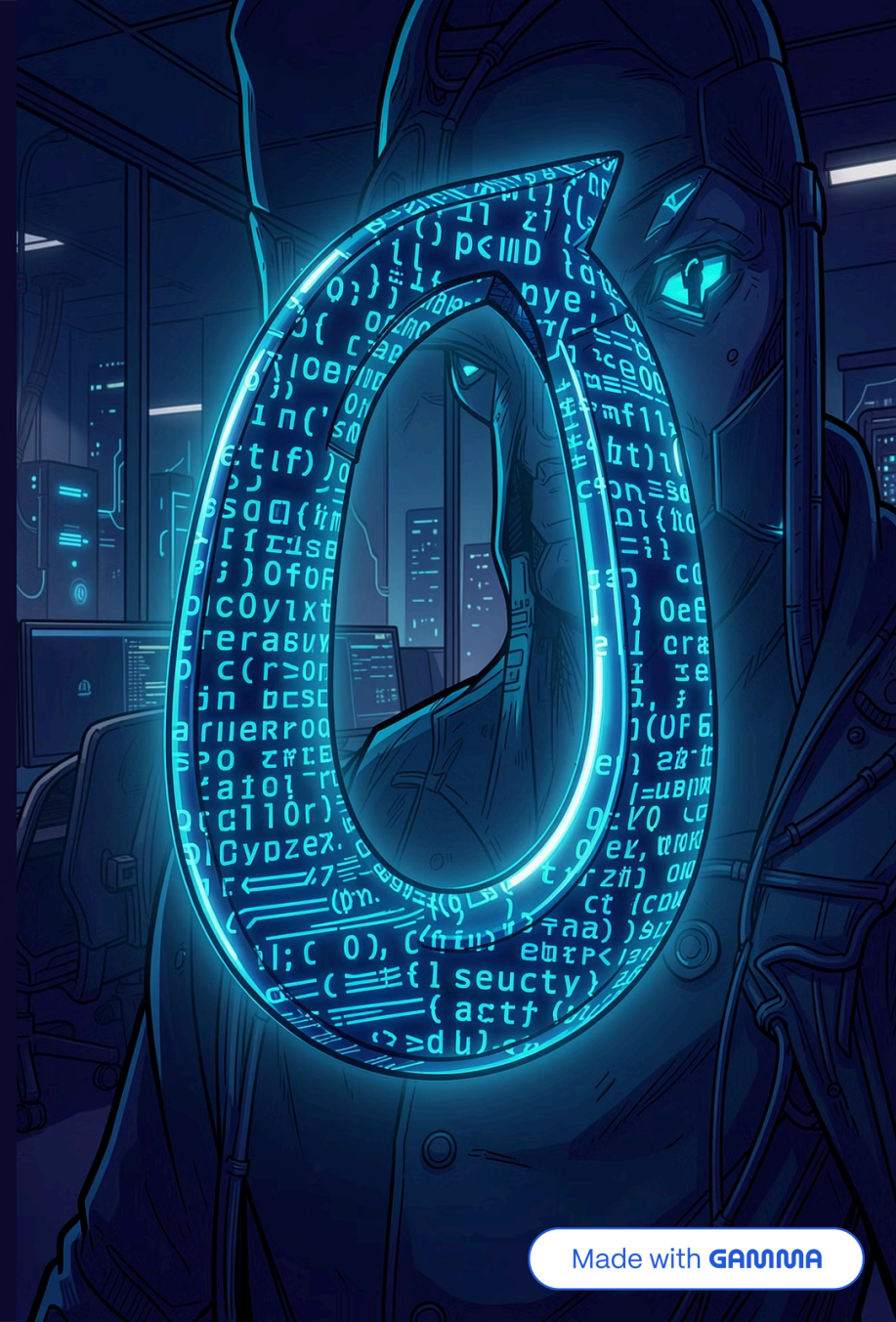


Phishing Awareness Training

Cybersecurity Internship Project

Practical guidance for employees, interns, and non-technical staff — identify, prevent, and respond to phishing attacks.



Agenda



Overview

What phishing is
and why it matters



Identify

Types, anatomy,
and common
indicators



Prevent

Best practices:
MFA, passwords,
verification



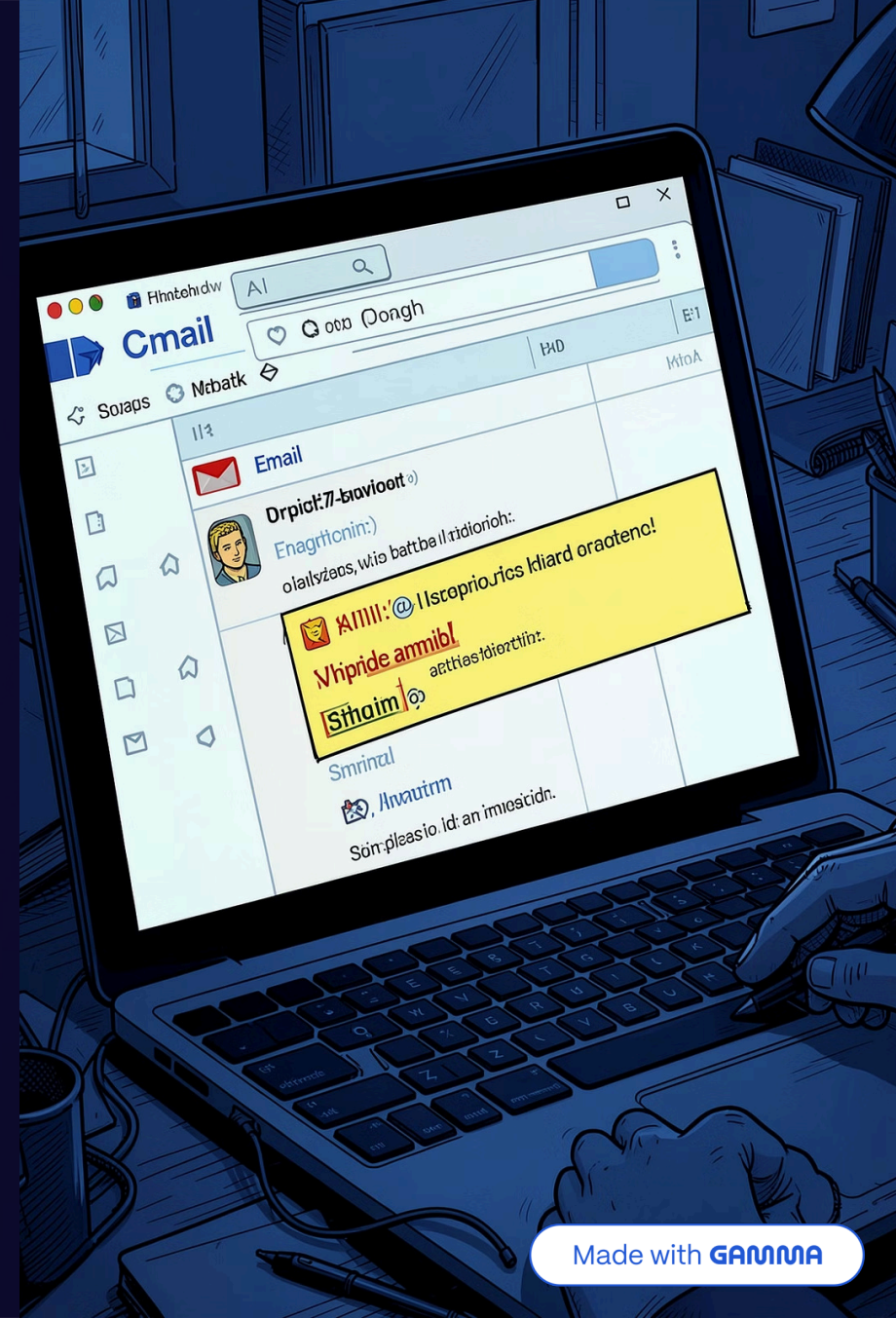
Respond

Incident reporting
and next steps

What is Phishing?

Phishing is a type of cyberattack where attackers impersonate trusted entities to trick users into revealing credentials, personal data, or installing malware. It is the most common initial vector for breaches and can lead to financial loss, data theft, and reputational damage.

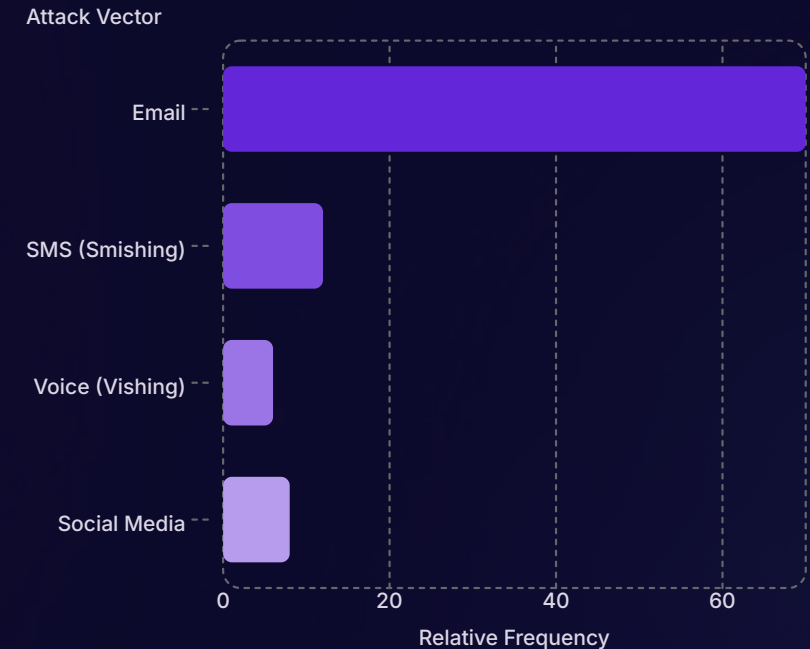
- ❏ Phishing preys on human trust — awareness and simple verification steps stop most attacks.



Current Phishing Landscape (2024–2025)

Phishing remains pervasive and increasingly targeted. Threat actors use AI-refined language and brand mimicry to bypass casual scrutiny. Rise in multi-channel attacks (email + SMS + voicemail) increases risk for employees who use the same credentials across services.

- Higher realism through personalized content
- Multi-channel campaigns (email, SMS, voice)
- Credential harvesting is still the primary goal



Relative distribution of phishing vectors. Email remains dominant, but SMS and voice are growing.

Types of Phishing



Email Phishing

Generic mass emails designed to trick recipients into clicking links or attachments.



Spear Phishing

Highly targeted attacks using personal or organizational details to increase credibility.



Whaling

Executive-focused attacks aimed at senior staff to extract high-value data or approvals.



Smishing

SMS-based phishing that uses urgent texts and malicious links to harvest credentials.



Vishing

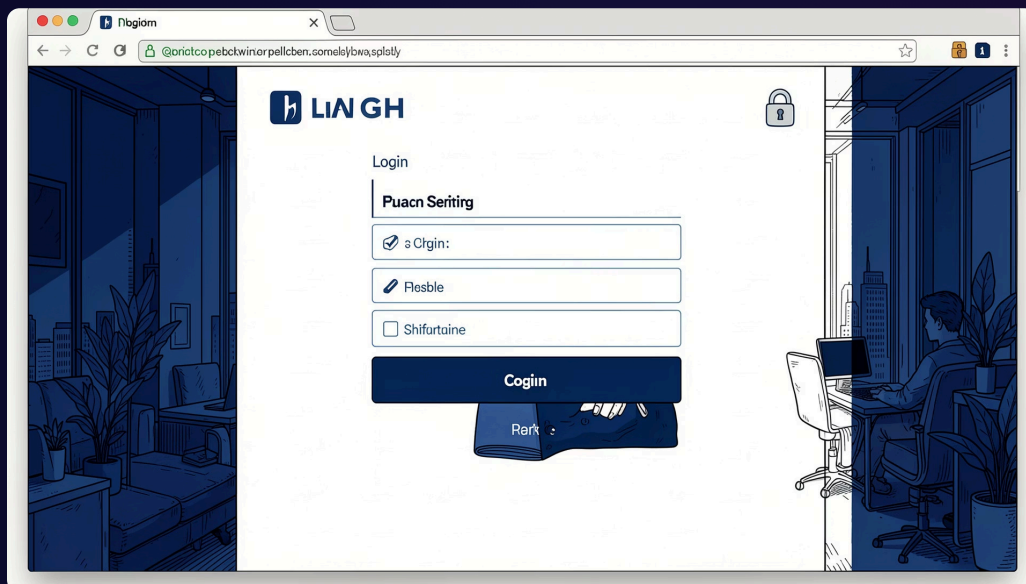
Voice calls that impersonate authority figures or helpdesk staff to extract sensitive information.



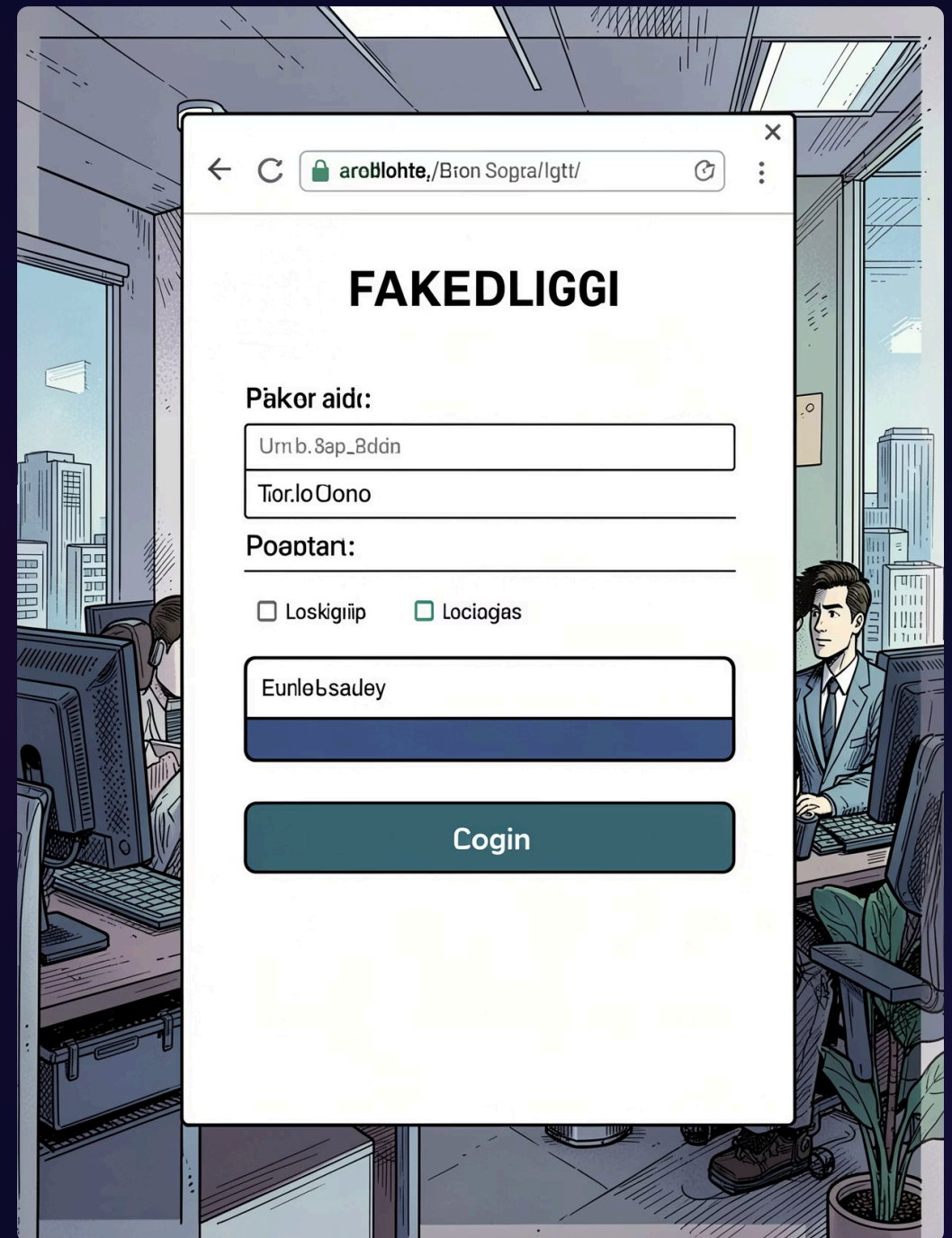
Key suspicious elements to watch for:

- Sender address and display name mismatch
- Urgent or threatening language prompting immediate action
- Links that redirect to unfamiliar domains (hover to inspect)
- Unexpected attachments or requests for credentials
- Generic greetings or poor grammar

Fake Website Example — Legitimate vs. Fake



Legitimate: HTTPS with valid certificate, correct domain, polished design, recognizable security indicators.



Fake: Subtle logo differences, misspelled domain, missing or invalid certificate, unexpected redirects. Always verify domain and certificate before entering credentials.

Social Engineering Techniques

Authority

Attackers impersonate leaders or IT to pressure action.

Urgency

Time pressure reduces scrutiny—pause before acting.

Fear

Threats of account suspension or consequences push quick responses.

Curiosity

Intriguing subject lines prompt clicks (attachments/links).

Trust Exploitation

Use of familiar logos, language, or prior communication to build credibility.

Recognizing these emotional triggers helps you slow down and verify before responding.

How to Identify Phishing Attempts

Hover Over Links
Preview URLs without clicking them.

Verify Attachments
Scan or confirm unexpected files first.

Inspect Sender
Check email address and domain closely.

Confirm Requests
Use a separate channel to validate.

Use this quick triage: 1) Inspect sender details and domain. 2) Hover (don't click) to preview link destinations. 3) Never open unexpected attachments—scan first. 4) Validate credential or transaction requests through a known, separate channel (phone, internal chat).

Prevention & Response — Best Practices

1

Enable MFA

Multi-factor authentication significantly reduces account takeover risk.

2

Use a Password Manager

Generates and stores unique passwords; prevents credential reuse across sites.

3

Verify Requests

For financial or access approvals, confirm via an independent channel.

4

Update & Patch

Keep devices and browsers up to date; apply security patches promptly.

Incident Response — Immediate Steps

- Do not click links or open attachments.
- Disconnect device from network if malware suspected.
- Report the message using the company reporting tool or security@company.com
- Change passwords on affected accounts and enable MFA if not already active.
- Follow instructions from Security team; preserve the phishing email for investigation.

 Reporting quickly helps Security block campaigns and protect the organization.